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Positional Logic and Planning

Turn quiet positions into concrete diagnoses, plans, and restrictions

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING	20

01. What Did The Last Move Change?



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Study the square a piece left as carefully as the square it reached.

PRIMARY PLAN

LANDING: Inspect new attacks and blocks.; ABSENCE: Inspect the vacated square and lines.; PROTECTION: Notice defenders that disappeared.; INTENT: Name the likely next idea.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They only developed' with 'Ask what became unguarded.'; Replace 'My plan still works' with 'Recheck the position after every move.'; Replace 'The threat is obvious' with 'Look for the quiet purpose too.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. d3 Nf6 5. O-O O-O 6. c3 d6 7. Re1

MEMORY RULE

Read the change first; make your plan second.

01. Decision Framework

What Did The Last Move Change?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	RESET: Forget your previous plan briefly.; LANDING: Scan attacks from the new square.; VACATED: Trace opened files and diagonals.; DEFENDERS: Recount critical protection.; RESPOND: Choose a move for the new position.
PIECE JOB	ARRIVAL: What does the moved piece attack from its new square?; DEPARTURE: What line or square did it stop protecting?; PURPOSE: What future idea became easier for the opponent?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTH ENDS: Every move changes two squares.; LINES: Vacated squares often reveal tactics.; DEFENDERS: Protection can vanish silently.; INTENT: Predict the next move, not only this one.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

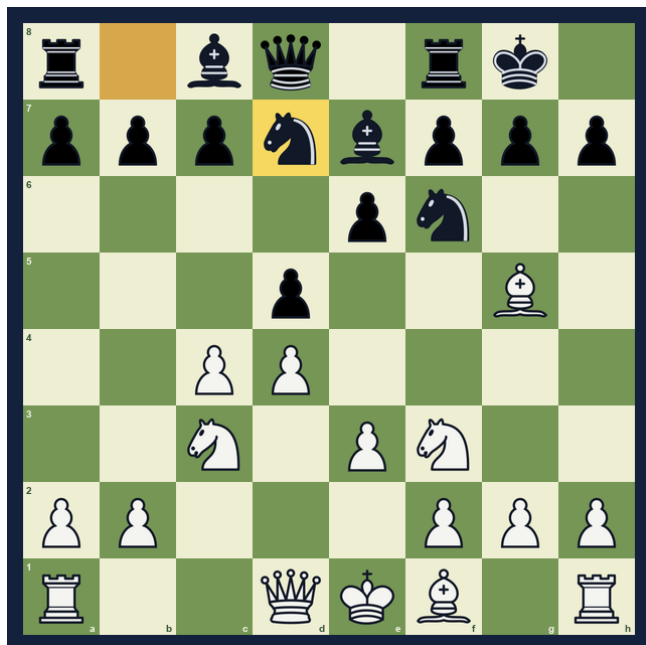
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Read the change first; make your plan second.

02. Find Your Worst Piece



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Improving the least useful piece can improve every other piece at once.

PRIMARY PLAN

JOB: What useful task is this piece doing?; SQUARES: How many safe, relevant squares exist?; RESTRICTION: Which pawn or piece limits it?; PATH: Can it improve without creating weakness?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I need an active move' with 'Improve the piece with no future.'; Replace 'A developed piece is fine' with 'Judge its job, not its location.'; Replace 'Two moves is too slow' with 'Use a route when the position is quiet.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

When you cannot find a plan, improve your worst piece.

02. Decision Framework

Find Your Worst Piece

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	SCAN: Look at every piece once.; RANK: Name the least useful piece.; DIAGNOSE: Find what restricts it.; ROUTE: Choose its best realistic square.; VERIFY: Check that tactics allow the plan.
PIECE JOB	ACTIVITY: Count useful squares, not distance from the center.; PURPOSE: A piece needs a job connected to the position.; ROUTE: The best improvement may require two quiet moves.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	BOTTLENECK: One bad piece can spoil a good position.; JOB: Activity must serve a purpose.; ROUTE: Quiet improvement can be concrete.; PATIENCE: Do not attack before your pieces can help.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When you cannot find a plan, improve your worst piece.

03. Compare The Two Kings



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Compare access, defenders, and attacking pieces before opening lines.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Count useful checking routes.; DEFENDERS: Count effective nearby defenders.; FORCES: Count attackers that can join quickly.; COST: Name what opening the position concedes.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Their king looks open' with 'Ask whether your pieces can reach it.'; Replace 'My king is castled' with 'Check lines and missing defenders.'; Replace 'I should sacrifice' with 'Count arriving forces before material.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

03. Decision Framework

Compare The Two Kings

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Inspect both kings, not only theirs.; ACCESS: Find checks that can actually arrive.; RECRUIT: Count pieces within two moves.; OPEN: Choose the safest useful line break.; RECHECK: Confirm your king survives the race.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Can checks reach the king without losing time?; DEFENDERS: Are nearby pieces able to protect critical squares?; FORCES: How many attackers can join before the position changes?
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELATIVE: King safety is always a comparison.; ACCESS: An exposed king may still be unreachable.; NUMBERS: Attack with more pieces than the defense.; COST: Opening lines works in both directions.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

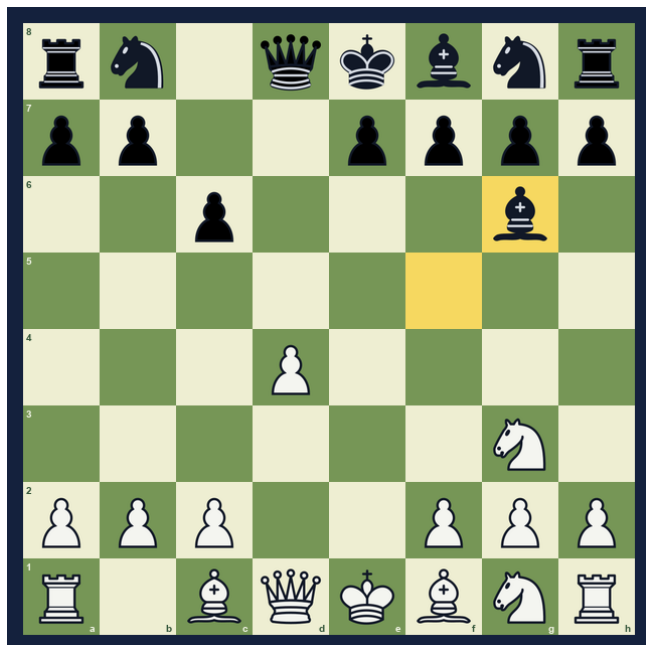
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not attack a picture; attack a king your pieces can reach.

04. Read The Pawn Skeleton



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Read direction, breaks, and fixed targets before choosing a plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

CHAINS: Find each chain's base and direction.; BREAKS: List realistic pawn breaks for both sides.; TARGETS: Mark pawns that cannot easily move.; SIDE: Play where your structure gives space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I will attack the king' with 'First see where your pawns point.'; Replace 'That pawn is weak' with 'Ask whether it can be reached.'; Replace 'A pawn move gains space' with 'Check which square it permanently weakens.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bf5 5. Ng3 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Let the pawns tell you where your pieces belong.

04. Decision Framework

Read The Pawn Skeleton

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FREEZE: Imagine the pieces removed.; TRACE: Follow both pawn chains.; BREAKS: Name each side's freeing move.; PLACE: Put pieces behind the likely break.; ACT: Prepare the break or prevent theirs.
PIECE JOB	DIRECTION: A pawn chain points toward the space you can gain.; BREAKS: Pawn breaks decide which files and diagonals will open.; TARGETS: Fixed pawns define long-term weaknesses.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	MAP: The skeleton predicts the battlefield.; BASE: Attack chains near their foundation.; BREAK: Prepare pawn moves with pieces first.; FIX: A target matters when it cannot escape.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Let the pawns tell you where your pieces belong.

05. Find The Important File



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Judge a file by its destination, control, and ability to support invasion.

PRIMARY PLAN

DESTINATION: What target lies at the end?; CONTROL: Who can double or challenge first?; ENTRY: Which square permits invasion?; PAYOFF: What changes if you occupy it?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Open file means rook' with 'Ask where the rook will enter.'; Replace 'Double automatically' with 'Check whether another piece needs improving.'; Replace 'Trade rooks on the file' with 'Keep them when your control has value.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

Do not occupy an open file until you know where it goes.

05. Decision Framework

Find The Important File

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	LIST: Find open and half-open files.; TRACE: Follow each file to a target.; ENTRY: Identify the best invasion square.; SUPPORT: Bring enough pieces to own it.; INVADE: Enter only when the square is secure.
PIECE JOB	DESTINATION: A file matters when it reaches a useful rank or target.; CONTROL: Ownership requires enough pieces to contest the line.; ENTRY: An invasion square must be safe and supportable.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PURPOSE: A file is a road, not a destination.; ENTRY: Control the invasion square first.; TIMING: Occupation matters only when it creates a threat.; TRADE: Exchange rooks only if the result favors you.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not occupy an open file until you know where it goes.

06. Spot The Real Weakness



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Call it real only if you can attack it, increase pressure, or force passivity.

PRIMARY PLAN

ACCESS: Can a piece reach the target safely?; PRESSURE:

Can you add attackers faster than defenders?;

CONCESSION: What does defense force them to abandon?;

MOBILITY: Can the target simply move away?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is an isolated pawn' with 'Prove you can reach

and pressure it.'; Replace 'I attacked it once' with 'Add

pressure or improve elsewhere.'; Replace 'They defended it'

with 'Notice what their defender stopped doing.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 Bd6 5. Bg3 O-O 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Attack weaknesses that force the opponent to live differently.

06. Decision Framework

Spot The Real Weakness

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Choose one possible target.; REACH: Find your best attacking route.; ADD: Locate a second attacker.; RESTRICT: Prevent the target from escaping.; EXPLOIT: Use the passivity you created.
PIECE JOB	ACCESS: Your pieces need a practical route to the target.; PRESSURE: You must be able to add another attacker.; CONCESSION: Defending it should restrict the opponent elsewhere.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	REACHABLE: A label alone does not create a weakness.; FIXED: Targets are valuable when they cannot move.; GROWING: Pressure must be able to increase.; PASSIVITY: The defender's burden is often the real prize.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack weaknesses that force the opponent to live differently.

07. Evaluate Before Choosing A Move



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Decide what the position needs before deciding how to provide it.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Are there urgent threats to either king?;
STRUCTURE: What will remain true after exchanges?;
ACTIVITY: Whose pieces have better jobs?; PRIORITY: Which imbalance matters most now?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I see a move I like' with 'Give the position a diagnosis first.'; Replace 'Material is equal' with 'Compare activity, safety, and structure.'; Replace 'Everything matters' with 'Choose the most urgent imbalance.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. d3 d6 7. c3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

07. Decision Framework

Evaluate Before Choosing A Move

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not generate moves immediately.; SAFETY: Rule out tactical urgency.; COMPARE: Check structure and activity.; PRIORITY: Name one thing to improve or attack.; GENERATE: Choose moves that serve that priority.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: Check kings and immediate tactical instability first.; STRUCTURE: Find lasting strengths, weaknesses, and pawn breaks.; ACTIVITY: Compare which pieces are useful and which are restricted.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	DIAGNOSE: Understand before prescribing a move.; COMPARE: Evaluation is always relative.; PRIORITY: One imbalance usually matters most.; PURPOSE: Candidate moves should solve a named problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

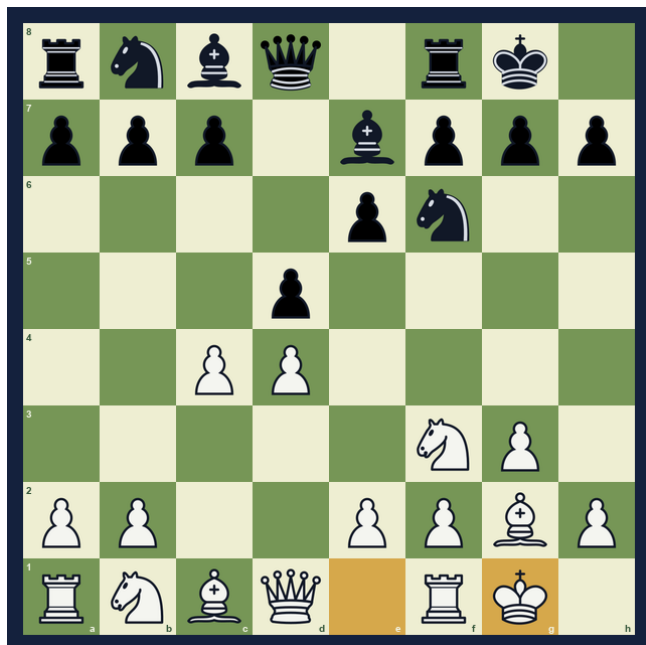
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A good move is easier to find after you know what good means.

08. What Is The Opponent'S Idea?



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Find the opponent's strongest useful continuation, then decide whether it must be stopped.

PRIMARY PLAN

THREAT: What happens if I make a waiting move?;
IMPROVE: Which of their pieces wants a better square?;
URGENCY: Can the idea wait one move?; RESPONSE: Can my move answer it while improving?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They attacked something' with 'Ask what happens if you ignore it.'; Replace 'I must stop their idea' with 'Judge whether it is actually urgent.'; Replace 'Defense means retreat' with 'Prefer a useful move with two purposes.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. g3 Be7 5. Bg2 O-O 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

08. Decision Framework

What Is The Opponent'S Idea?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	WAIT: Imagine passing your turn.; PREDICT: Name their strongest next move.; VALUE: Judge what that move would gain.; DECIDE: Stop, delay, or ignore it.; MULTIPURPOSE: Choose a response that also improves.
PIECE JOB	THREAT: A real threat changes material, king safety, or structure.; IMPROVEMENT: A quiet move may activate their worst piece.; URGENCY: Some ideas can be met after you improve your own position.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PREDICT: Name one serious opponent idea.; TEST: Use a waiting move to expose urgency.; SELECT: Not every idea deserves prevention.; IMPROVE: The best defense often serves your plan too.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

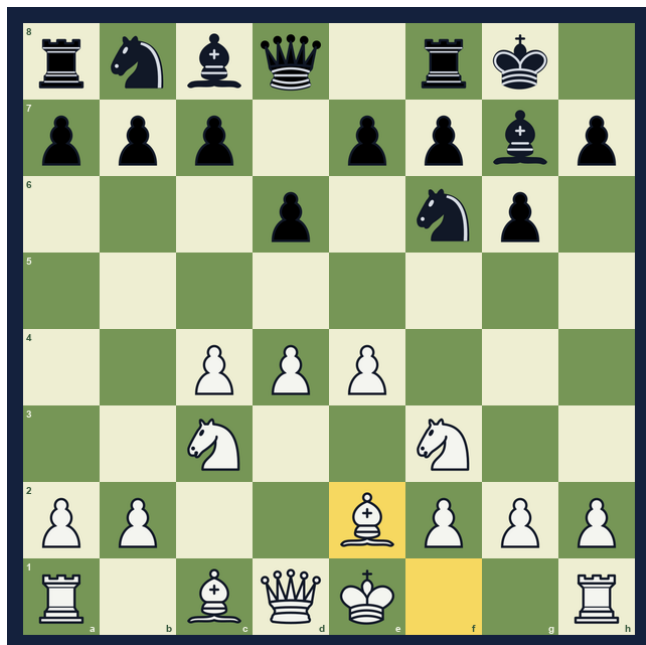
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: See their idea clearly, then respond by choice rather than fear.

09. Improve Before You Attack



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Bring the least active useful piece into play before forcing the position open.

PRIMARY PLAN

PARTICIPANTS: Count active attacking pieces.; RESTRICT: Remove or limit key defenders.; BREAK: Identify the line-opening move.; COUNTERPLAY: Check what the opponent gets in return.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'A threat means an attack' with 'Count how many pieces can follow.'; Replace 'Open lines immediately' with 'Place pieces before changing the structure.'; Replace 'Sacrifice to keep momentum' with 'Improve the last attacker first.'

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2

MEMORY RULE

The strongest attacking move is often the move that invites one more piece.

09. Decision Framework

Improve Before You Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COUNT: Name every possible participant.; IMPROVE: Recruit the worst useful piece.; RESTRICT: Challenge the best defender.; PREPARE: Support the intended pawn break.; OPEN: Strike when the pieces are ready.
PIECE JOB	PARTICIPATION: Count pieces that can reach the target quickly.; RESTRICTION: Limit defensive pieces before sacrificing material or structure.; BREAK: Open lines only after your pieces occupy them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NUMBERS: A real attack needs enough participants.; ORDER: Place pieces before opening lines.; DEFENDERS: Restriction can be stronger than a threat.; PATIENCE: One quiet move may make the attack unavoidable.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

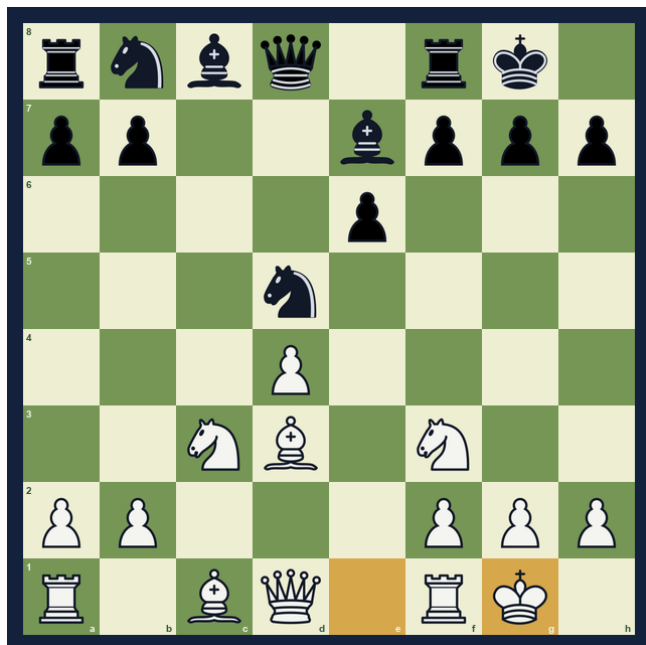
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The strongest attacking move is often the move that invites one more piece.

10. When To Trade Pieces



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Evaluate the position after the exchange, not the pieces disappearing from it.

PRIMARY PLAN

REMOVE: Which opponent piece is most useful?
 STRUCTURE: What pawn structure remains?; ENDGAME: Who benefits from fewer pieces?; ACTIVITY: Which remaining piece gains freedom?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Equal pieces can be traded' with 'Picture what improves after the trade.'; Replace 'I am ahead, so simplify' with 'Keep enough activity to convert.'; Replace 'Trade their attacker' with 'Check whether its replacement is stronger.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 cxd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Nf3 Be7 7. cxd5 Nxd5 8. Bd3 O-O 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

10. Decision Framework

When To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PICTURE: Remove both pieces mentally.; RECOUNT: Compare the remaining active pieces.; STRUCTURE: Inspect recaptures and new pawn targets.; ENDGAME: Judge the likely simplified position.; DECIDE: Trade only for a named benefit.
PIECE JOB	RELIEF: Exchange the opponent's piece that creates the most pressure.; STRUCTURE: Use trades that leave a durable target or passed pawn.; ENDGAME: Simplify when the remaining position is easier for you to play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	FUTURE: An exchange is a positional transformation.; BEST PIECE: Trade what makes their position work.; RECAPTURE: The recapturing piece may gain activity.; CONVERSION: Simplification helps only if the ending helps.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not ask whether the pieces are equal; ask which position is better.

11. When Not To Trade Pieces



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Decline exchanges when your piece, space, or tension forces the opponent to remain uncomfortable.

PRIMARY PLAN

SPACE: Who needs room more urgently?; PRESSURE: Which piece maintains a useful burden?; TENSION: What options disappear after the exchange?; REPLACEMENT: What piece takes over the traded square?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'They offered a trade' with 'Ask whose problem the trade solves.'; Replace 'Avoiding trades is passive' with 'Preserve pieces that create pressure.'; Replace 'Capture to clarify' with 'Keep tension when uncertainty favors you.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3 Be7 5. Bg5 O-O 6. e3 Nbd7 7. Qc2 c5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

11. Decision Framework

When Not To Trade Pieces

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PAUSE: Do not recapture automatically.; COMPARE: Identify who is cramped or pressured.; REMOVE: Visualize both pieces gone.; REPLACE: See which piece or pawn takes over.; CHOOSE: Maintain tension if it keeps options.
PIECE JOB	SPACE: The cramped side often wants pieces removed.; PRESSURE: An attacking piece may be worth more than its nominal value.; TENSION: Unresolved contact can restrict more than an immediate capture.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	RELIEF: Do not release a cramped opponent for free.; VALUE: Active pieces can exceed book value.; OPTIONS: Tension preserves choices and restricts replies.; PURPOSE: Every exchange should solve your problem.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Keep the pieces and tensions that make the opponent's life difficult.

12. Create A Second Weakness



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Fix one weakness, then create another where the same defenders cannot serve both.

PRIMARY PLAN

FIX: Make the first weakness permanent.; TRANSFER: Prepare pieces to switch flanks.; CREATE: Produce a second point of entry.; SWITCH: Attack whichever target is underdefended.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Pile onto one pawn' with 'Fix it, then widen the battlefield.'; Replace 'Change sides immediately' with 'Prepare a fast transfer first.'; Replace 'Force the breakthrough' with 'Let overload create the breakthrough.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Make the defender choose which weakness to lose.

12. Decision Framework

Create A Second Weakness

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	FIX: Stop the first target escaping.; TIE: Force a defender into passivity.; PREPARE: Centralize pieces for transfer.; CREATE: Open a distant weakness.; SWITCH: Attack the slower defensive side.
PIECE JOB	FIX: Prevent the first target from moving or trading away.; TRANSFER: Improve pieces so they can change sides quickly.; CREATE: Use a pawn break or invasion to make a distant target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE: One weakness may only create passivity.; DISTANCE: The second target should be far away.; TRANSFER: Your pieces must switch faster.; PATIENCE: Overload wins before tactics appear.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Make the defender choose which weakness to lose.

13. Good Bishop Or Bad Bishop?



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Judge its diagonals, targets, and defensive duties in the actual position.

PRIMARY PLAN

SCOPE: Count useful squares and diagonals.; TARGETS: What can the bishop affect?; FUTURE: Which pawn break opens or closes it?; EXCHANGE: Would trading it improve the remaining structure?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Same-color pawns mean bad' with 'Check whether the bishop has a useful job.'; Replace 'Open diagonal means good' with 'Look for a real target on it.'; Replace 'Trade the bad bishop' with 'Ask what squares it currently protects.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Judge the bishop you have, not the slogan you remember.

13. Decision Framework

Good Bishop Or Bad Bishop?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	TRACE: Follow every available diagonal.; FILTER: Keep only relevant destinations.; TARGET: Name what the bishop influences.; BREAK: Find the pawn move that changes its scope.; DECIDE: Improve, exchange, or preserve it.
PIECE JOB	SCOPE: Useful squares matter more than the length of a diagonal.; TARGETS: A bishop needs something relevant to attack or defend.; FUTURE: A pawn break may completely change its quality.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	JOB: A bishop's usefulness is concrete.; SCOPE: Long does not always mean relevant.; BREAK: Pawn moves can transform the piece.; DEFENSE: A restricted bishop may hold vital squares.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

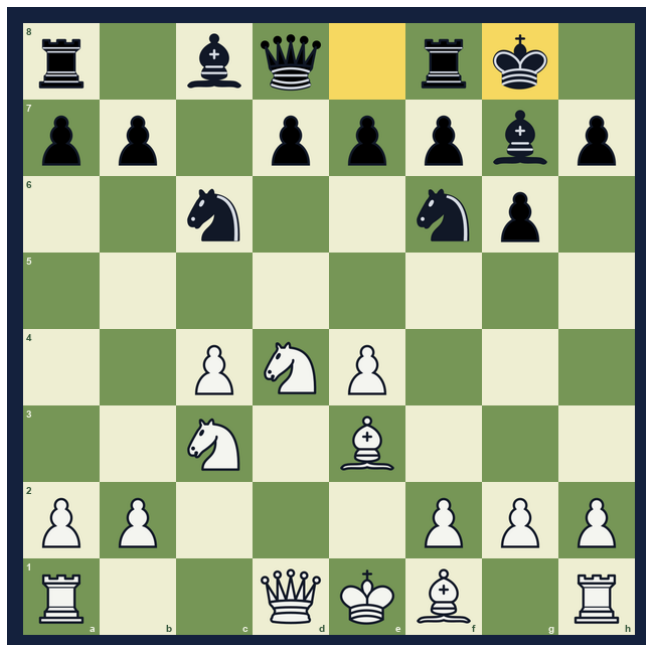
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Judge the bishop you have, not the slogan you remember.

14. Build A Real Outpost



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Use a square that cannot be chased and from which the piece influences something important.

PRIMARY PLAN

STABLE: Can an enemy pawn challenge the square?;
SUPPORTED: Can the piece remain there safely?;
INFLUENCE: What useful squares or targets does it affect?;
ROUTE: Can the piece reach it without losing time?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'It is a central square' with 'Prove the piece cannot be chased.'; Replace 'A knight belongs there' with 'Ask what the knight does from there.'; Replace 'Occupy it immediately' with 'Prepare support and a safe route.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. c4 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Nc3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

14. Decision Framework

Build A Real Outpost

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MARK: Find squares enemy pawns cannot control.; VALUE: Choose one with real influence.; SUPPORT: Secure it with a pawn or piece.; ROUTE: Find the safest path inward.; OCCUPY: Enter when exchanges favor you.
PIECE JOB	STABILITY: Enemy pawns cannot drive the piece away.; SUPPORT: Your pawn or piece can maintain the occupant.; INFLUENCE: The square attacks targets or restricts important play.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	STABLE: A true outpost cannot be chased by pawns.; USEFUL: The occupant must affect the game.; SUPPORTED: Do not turn the outpost into a trap.; ROUTE: Preparation is part of occupation.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

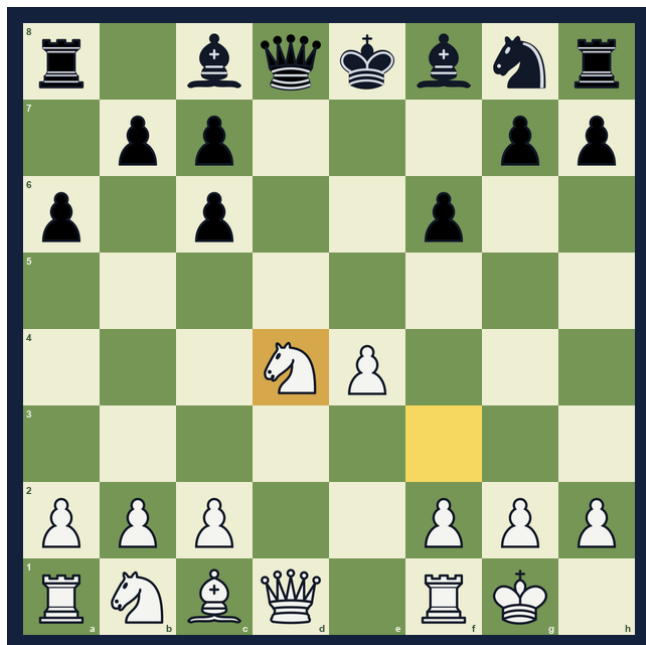
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A strong square is valuable only when a strong piece can use it.

15. Use A Space Advantage



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Use extra territory to improve pieces and restrict breaks before forcing action.

PRIMARY PLAN

ROOM: Which piece gains the best maneuvering route?; RESTRICT: Which enemy piece has no square?; BREAKS: What freeing pawn move do they need?; PROTECT: Which advanced pawn could become weak?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Space means attack now' with 'Improve pieces while they remain cramped.'; Replace 'Push another pawn' with 'Protect the territory already gained.'; Replace 'Trade pieces freely' with 'Keep pieces when the opponent lacks space.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4 exd4 7. Nxd4

MEMORY RULE

Use space to improve quietly until the opponent runs out of useful moves.

15. Decision Framework

Use A Space Advantage

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	IDENTIFY: Find the cramped enemy piece.; PREVENT: Control their freeing pawn break.; MANEUVER: Improve your least useful piece.; PROTECT: Reinforce advanced pawns.; OPEN: Break through only when ready.
PIECE JOB	ROOM: Your pieces can switch squares without blocking one another.; RESTRICTION: Enemy pieces have fewer useful destinations.; RISK: Advanced pawns can become targets if support disappears.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ROOM: Space is useful maneuvering capacity.; KEEP PIECES: Crowding hurts the side with less space.; BREAKS: Stop the move that would free them.; CONTROL: Do not let advanced pawns become targets.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Use space to improve quietly until the opponent runs out of useful moves.

16. Prepare The Pawn Break



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Support the break, occupy the lines it will open, and calculate the opponent's best reaction.

PRIMARY PLAN

SUPPORT: Is the breaking pawn adequately supported?;
 PLACEMENT: Which pieces improve after lines open?;
 RESPONSES: Test capture, advance, and refusal.; OUTCOME:
 Which structure remains after each reply?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'The break is thematic' with 'Check whether the pieces are ready now.'; Replace 'They must capture' with 'Calculate advance and refusal too.'; Replace 'Open position is good' with 'Name which pieces actually improve.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

16. Decision Framework

Prepare The Pawn Break

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	NAME: Identify the structural break.; PLACE: Move pieces onto future lines.; SUPPORT: Reinforce the advancing pawn.; TEST: Calculate all three responses.; BREAK: Play it when every reply helps.
PIECE JOB	SUPPORT: The advancing pawn needs enough protection or tactical justification.; PLACEMENT: Rooks and bishops should face the lines that will open.; RESPONSE: The opponent may capture, advance, or ignore the break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	PERMANENT: Pawn breaks cannot be taken back.; PREPARE: Place pieces before opening lines.; RESPONSES: Capture is only one possible reply.; RESULT: Evaluate the resulting structure, not the push.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The best pawn break is prepared before it becomes urgent.

17. Stop Counterplay Without Passivity



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Identify the freeing break, invasion square, or active piece that gives the opponent play.

PRIMARY PLAN

SOURCE: What creates their active play?; CONTROL: Can one move block or discourage it?; PROGRESS: Does the move improve your own position?; RELEASE: What happens if they achieve the break?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Stop every threat' with 'Find the one source of activity.'; Replace 'Defend with retreat' with 'Use control, trades, or a useful blockade.'; Replace 'Keep attacking' with 'Spend one move removing their best resource.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5 9. Nd5 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

17. Decision Framework

Stop Counterplay Without Passivity

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	PREDICT: Name their best active idea.; TRACE: Find the break or square it needs.; BLOCK: Choose the smallest effective restraint.; IMPROVE: Make the move serve your plan too.; CONTINUE: Return to conversion after control.
PIECE JOB	SOURCE: Counterplay usually depends on one break, file, or piece.; CONTROL: A single square can sometimes stop the entire idea.; PROGRESS: Your restraining move should preserve a path forward.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	ONE SOURCE: Counterplay is often structurally narrow.; MINIMUM: Use the least passive effective move.; DUAL PURPOSE: Restriction should also improve.; RETURN: Once controlled, continue your own plan.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Good prevention does not stop your game; it clears the road for it.

18. Keep Or Release The Tension?



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Compare capture, advance, and waiting before changing the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

CAPTURE: What improves after the likely recapture?; ADVANCE: What squares become fixed or weak?; WAIT: Who benefits from maintaining tension?; REPLY: Can the opponent resolve it more favorably?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Capture to simplify' with 'Inspect the opponent's recapturing piece.'; Replace 'Advance to gain space' with 'Count the squares left behind.'; Replace 'I must decide now' with 'Wait when tension restricts them more.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

MEMORY RULE

Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

18. Decision Framework

Keep Or Release The Tension?

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	COMPARE: Picture all three structural choices.; RECAPTURE: Place the opponent's piece after capture.; FIX: See what an advance makes permanent.; WAIT: Measure who has more useful options.; TIME: Resolve only for a concrete gain.
PIECE JOB	OPTIONS: Maintaining contact preserves more choices for you.; RECAPTURE: The opponent's recapturing piece may improve dramatically.; TIMING: A favorable resolution today may be unfavorable one move later.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	THREE CHOICES: Capture and advance are not the only moves.; RECAPTURE: Structure and activity change together.; OPTIONS: Tension can be a form of control.; TIMING: Resolve contact when the result favors you.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

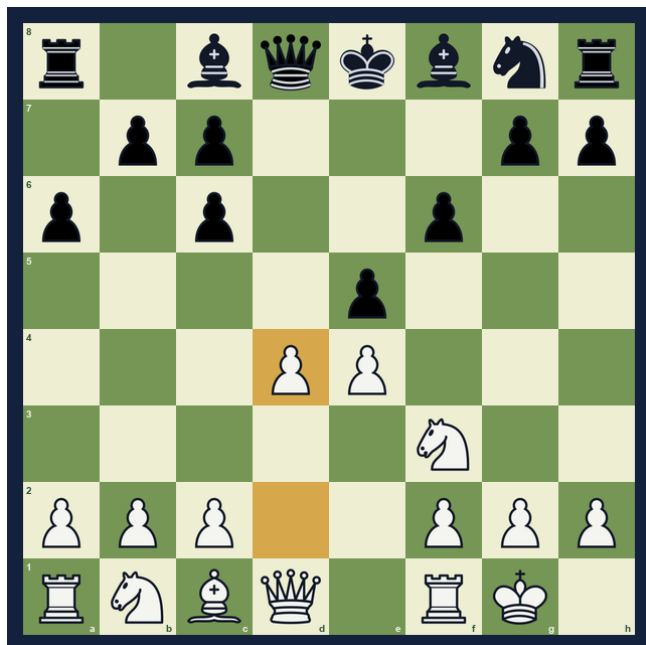
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not release tension merely to make the position easier to understand.

19. Control A Color Complex



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Enter through one square, then transfer to another faster than the defense can respond.

PRIMARY PLAN

PAWNS: Which color can their pawns no longer cover?

BISHOP: Is the matching bishop absent or restricted?

ENTRY: Which weak square can you reach first?; ROUTE:

Where can the piece transfer next?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'Attack one weak square' with 'Use it as an entry into a network.'; Replace 'Trade bishops automatically' with 'Check which colors become undefended.'; Replace 'Push a pawn to chase' with 'Notice the new squares the push abandons.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Bxc6 dxc6 5. O-O f6 6. d4

MEMORY RULE

Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

19. Decision Framework

Control A Color Complex

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	MAP: Mark the weak squares of one color.; REMOVE: Exchange the natural defender if useful.; ENTER: Occupy the safest access square.; TRANSFER: Move between related targets.; FIX: Prevent pawns from repairing the complex.
PIECE JOB	PAWNS: Pawn moves permanently abandon squares of the opposite color.; BISHOP: Trading a bishop can remove the natural color defender.; ROUTES: Queens and knights can move through several related weak squares.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	NETWORK: Several weak squares support one another.; BISHOP: The missing color defender matters greatly.; ENTRY: One square can unlock the whole position.; PAWNS: Every pawn move gives up squares forever.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

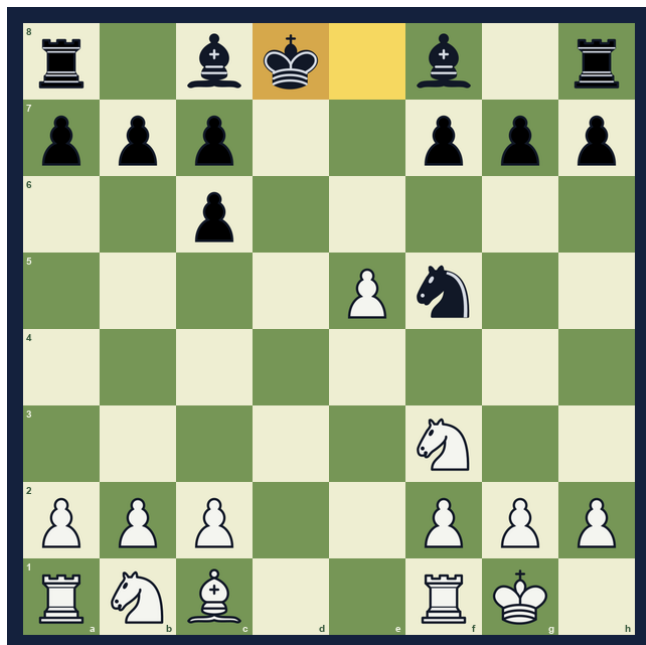
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not merely occupy a weak square; use it to travel through the position.

20. When You Have No Idea What To Do



POSITIONAL LOGIC AND PLANNING

READ THE POSITION

Remove immediate danger, improve the worst piece, or preserve useful options.

PRIMARY PLAN

SAFETY: Is anything loose or tactically vulnerable?; IMPROVE: Which piece has the least useful job?; FLEXIBLE: Which move preserves options?; OPPONENT: What idea should not be allowed?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Replace 'I need a plan' with 'Solve one concrete problem first.'; Replace 'Make a pawn move' with 'Prefer reversible piece improvement.'; Replace 'Copy a known idea' with 'Use what this position actually needs.'

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Nxe4 5. d4 Nd6 6. Bxc6 dxc6 7. dxe5 Nf5 8. Qxd8+ Kxd8

MEMORY RULE

When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

20. Decision Framework

When You Have No Idea What To Do

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	BREATHE: Stop demanding a perfect move.; SAFETY: Remove tactical defects.; IMPROVE: Help the worst piece.; PRESERVE: Avoid unnecessary pawn commitments.; PLAY: Choose a sound move and continue.
PIECE JOB	SAFETY: A safe position gives future plans time to appear.; IMPROVEMENT: One better piece can reveal the next step.; FLEXIBILITY: A noncommittal move can keep several plans available.
TACTICAL WARNING	Use forcing moves only after the framework identifies what the position demands.
TRADE FILTER	Picture the resulting position and name what improves, disappears, or becomes weak.
ENDGAME FORECAST	SMALL: A useful move need not solve everything.; SAFE: Stability creates future opportunities.; REVERSIBLE: Piece moves preserve more options than pawn moves.; REAL: Respond to the position, not your memory.
CLOCK RULE	Use the routine quickly in familiar positions and spend extra time only when the decision is forcing or irreversible.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When you have no plan, make the position easier for your future self.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.